

Review

Reviewed Work(s): The Abraham Accords: The Gulf States, Israel, and the Limits of Normalization by Elham Fakhro

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Fakhro, Elham. *The Abraham Accords: The Gulf States, Israel, and the Limits of Normalization.*
New York: Columbia University Press, 2024.
352 pages. Hardcover $35.00

Elham Fakhro sets out to answer a few questions about the Abraham Accords, from the Gulf perspective. These are: Why did the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Bahrain decide to open up and formalize their trade relations with Israel? What does the normalization reveal about the Gulf foreign policy and its stance toward the Palestine question? What does the Agreement tell us about US foreign policy in the Middle East? What is the role of the Trump administration in bringing about the signing of the Accords on August 13, 2020? And finally, how was the Agreement received in the Gulf region, Palestine, and the Arab world? And what are the limitations of the Agreement? The book comprises six chapters with an introduction and conclusion.

Chapter 1 contextualizes the Arab–Israeli conflict socially, financially, and diplomatically and its impact on the people and governments of the Gulf. We learn that the traditionally positive support for the Palestine cause by the people and leadership during the early period after the *Nakba* had begun to shift since the Oslo process. The shift and its causes are the subject of Chapter 2. It zeros in on the changing perceptions of Israel by the leaders of the UAE and Bahrain for four reasons. The rise of Shi'a Iran as a regional power since 2006, Hizbollah's success in evicting Israel from Lebanon, the Arab Spring of 2010–2011, and above all, the emergence in both countries of young leaders, whose Western education has veered them toward US policies regarding Iran. All these factors have exacerbated the Suni-Shi'a divide in the region and reshaped Gulf foreign policies. Chapter 3 details President Donald Trump's role in sealing the deal of the century, as he put it. We learn about the politically inexperienced team of pro-Israel advisors he assembled for his campaign – Zionist Jews and Evangelical Christians – such as his son-in-law Jared Kushner, his attorney David Freedman, and his chief legal officer Jason Greenblatt, among others, who managed to "elevate Israel's interests to the top of the presidential agenda" (76). The image of Trump that emerges from the meticulous documents presented reveals his approach to politics as a "family business," similar to the royals of the Gulf (77). Trapped in their perceived fear of Shi'a Iran and aware of the fragility of their authoritarian regimes, the undemocratically elected rulers looked up to the power of the US–Israel alliance for protection. While Chapter 4 elaborates on the UAE-Israel trade cooperation prior to the signing of the Accords, Chapter 5 dives deeper into Bahrain's specific issues, given the fact that the majority of Bahrainis are Shi'a, ruled by a Sunni monarch.

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Having experienced a wave of the Arab Spring, Bahrain felt the threat more so than the UAE, but both countries saw Israel as an asset in thwarting Iran's threat, hence the normalization. This chapter elaborates on Bahrain's propaganda campaigns to promote its tolerant and liberal image in the West. As detailed by Fakhro, they are purely farcical, but the author retains her objective stance as she documents the government's various venues, personnel, and organizations, while cracking down on opposition at home, closing down independent newspapers, imprisoning journalists, and banning political parties. Being the capitalist states they are, it seems that the rulers of Bahrain and the UAE have embraced the US–Israel propaganda campaign against Iran, and their deep concerns regarding their survival and security pressured them to align themselves with the enemy. Chapter 6 describes the reactions to the signing of the Accords. People in the two countries, the Gulf at large, and the Palestinians have protested against it. Adding to the discussion of the limitations of the Accords, Fakhro mentions left-wing Israelis' opposition for fear of strengthening Netanyahu's intentions to continue the occupation of the West Bank and Gaza. It is not surprising to learn that supporters of the Accords include most Israelis and an elite minority of Westernized (I would say neocolonial) Gulf citizens. The conclusion, titled "October 7 and Beyond" sketches the historical attack by Hamas and the ensuing Israeli response against Gaza. One wonders if Fakhro is self-censoring by refraining from calling the "the 2023 Gaza War" (223) a genocide, though she relates the atrocities committed by Israel against civilians in Gaza. She rightly points out that October 7 has succeeded in refocusing Arab and world attention on the Palestine question, though trade relations between the UAE, Jordan, and Egypt have not been affected, by June 2024.

The Abraham Accords is an excellent scholarly work that provides valuable documentation about the normalization of relations between some Gulf countries with Israel. Fakhro's research, lucid style, and accessibility will appeal to academic readers and beyond.

Notes

1. Salman Abu-Sitta, and Terry Rampel, "The ICRC and the Detention of Palestinian Civilians in Israel in 1948 POW/Labor Camps," *Journal of Palestine Studies* 43.4, 11–38.
2. It is noteworthy to mention that the first independent survey of deaths in Gaza reports (June 27, 2025) that the numbers of deaths are close to 80,000 Palestinian civilian, according to *Nature* magazine. Rachel Fieldhouse, *Nature*, https://www.nature.com/articles/d41586-025-02009-8

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